

Field Notes on Small-Team Software S

SPECIAL DOCUMENT

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SECTION TITLE: The Honest BottleneckThe real constraint is not tooling or cloud cost--it is decision latency. Small teams ship fast when one person can say "yes" to a change without a change advisory board. They ship slowly when product, legal, or security reviews become mandatory. We are uncertain whether this pattern holds for teams above 8 people, but for 3-6, the data (anecdotal, from ~20 startup post-mortems) suggests that review gates add more delay than any technical debt. The honest take: small teams ship because they are willing to break things, not because they are smarter--and they break things more often than they admit in their status reports.